

and Google's got us conditioned a little better to accept that it's the service to use to find answers to serious questions.

To put it even more simply, it's OK to be an idiot on Google, but embarrassing if you're one on Facebook!

That may look like a harmless sentence, but it defines how we use those two services. We use Google to get knowledge, and use Facebook to "show off" that knowledge. In essence, although many would believe that we're more "real" on Facebook, we're actually more "real-world" on Facebook, exhibiting all our insecurities and donning all our masks to hide our flaws – an online version of us at a party or social gathering. Hardly "real". Advertisers are more interested in your real needs, and not your opinion. They want you when you're questioning things like "What should I buy", "Where should I buy from?", etc., which is something we seem to be more open about to a search engine, obviously.

Cleaning up after the party

One of the other things Facebook has to worry about is the fact that a lot of its people are going to get rich. It's a good problem for the people to have, but not for the company. It's common for thinkers

"For a site that makes almost all its money from advertising, and which claims 96 of the top 100 US advertisers as customers, Facebook harbors a dirty little secret: Marketing on Facebook doesn't work very well. In fact, user engagement rates on branded pages are declining rather than increasing, and most large marketers tell us they simply haven't gotten much value from their Facebook investments."

Nate Elliott, Forrester

<http://bit.ly/A3wIjJ>

who get rich to want to branch out on their own and start something of their own. The entrepreneurship bug has been biting people for ages now, and especially in the technology field, it seems to be biting hard.

Chamath Paliapitiya, "VP of Growth, Mobile, and International" at Facebook, quit last year to go off on his own. His goodbye note was published online at

TechCrunch.com, and some of his words were quite interesting:

"We risk becoming like everyone else. the only chance we have is the discipline and resolve of the silent majority who needs to and MUST become more vocal as the company gets bigger. fight for the culture the way it should be...not the way it was or the way its becoming."

The part of his farewell speech that's most interesting to us is: "Be afraid of the company you don't know. There is someone out there lurking with a small idea that will grow into a giant."

That's what we feel is Facebook's biggest threat – the unknown competition. We users are a fickle bunch, especially when the services in question cost us nothing. If Google pushed too much advertising too soon, we'd all be using some other search engine today. Facebook is massive, and has close to a billion people on it already, but that means its growth in user base will start slowing. If we look at Twitter, LinkedIn and GroupOn, who went the IPO way, and currently sit on share prices that are way below opening day, Facebook has a tough task ahead if it's to break the social networking IPO trend.

What if it fails?

Billions will be lost or earned off the stock market if such a doomsday scenario were to occur, of course. To you and me, well nothing, really. We'll just shove off to Google+ or some other me-too new service that's hot at the time.

Perhaps, it would spell the death-knell for Internet businesses. Who's going to invest in such businesses? If a service as big and popular as Facebook can fail, what's to say everything else won't?

Remember MySpace? You know... that other social network that overtook Google in terms of traffic a few years ago, and promised to be The Next Big Thing!™ It was bought up by News Corp in 2005 for \$590 million and sold in 2011 to Justin Timberlake and others for \$35 million.

Yes, the web is a fickle beast, and it would be very silly indeed to think this couldn't happen to Facebook, or any other such service, for that matter. For now, those serious about their networking skills should make sure they give their Google+ account some love as well, and also remember to take offline backups of Facebook data from time to time. 

How much will everyone be worth?

Assuming the expected \$100 billion value of Facebook

